

FREE STARTER

The Field Cheat Sheet

Your Free Photography, Video & Drone Quick-Reference

Story Mode Guy

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What's Inside

Your Free Photography, Video & Drone Quick-Reference. Written for anyone starting out who wants a printable quick-reference.

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Your Free Field Cheat Sheet

Keep this in your camera bag. It's the fastest, most useful bits from the full Story Mode Guy libraries — exposure starting points, a sharpness fix, the light, the video shutter rule, and a drone pre-flight — all on a few printable pages. No fluff.

This is the **free** starter. If it helps, the full guides go far deeper — but you can get real results with just what's on these pages. Print it, dog-ear it, and take it shooting.



How to use this

Don't memorize it — *use* it. Pick the card that matches what's in front of you, dial in the starting point, then adjust by what your eyes and histogram tell you.

CARD 01

Exposure Quick-Start

Start here, then fine-tune. These are reliable starting points for common scenes — not rigid rules.

Bright daylight portrait

STARTING POINT

Aperture **f/2.8**

Shutter **1/500s**

ISO **100**

Wide aperture for a soft background. Watch for blown highlights on skin.

Landscape, everything sharp

STARTING POINT

Aperture **f/8-f/11**

Shutter **auto**

ISO **100**

Tripod if the shutter drops below 1/60s. Focus about a third into the scene.

Indoors / low light

STARTING POINT

Aperture **f/1.8-f/2.8**

Shutter **1/125s**

ISO **800-3200**

Let ISO rise before the shutter drops too slow to hand-hold. Noise beats blur.

REMEMBER

Aperture controls depth. Shutter controls motion. ISO is the last resort for brightness. Move one, compensate with another.

CARD 02

The 10-Second Sharpness Fix

Blurry shots aren't bad luck — they're one of three problems. Diagnose, then fix.

What you see	The cause	The fix
The whole frame is soft	Camera shake	Faster shutter ($\geq 1/\text{focal length}$); brace or use a tripod
Background sharp, subject smeared	Subject motion	Faster shutter to match: walking 1/250s, running 1/500s+
Something's sharp — just not your subject	Missed focus	Single-point AF on the eye; stop down to f/2.8–f/4



The silent culprit

Most blur is a too-slow shutter you never noticed because the camera was on Auto in dim light. Watch that number.

CARD 03

The Light: Golden & Blue Hour

The single biggest upgrade to any photo is *when* you shoot it.

- ✓ **Golden hour** — the hour after sunrise / before sunset. Soft, warm, directional. The most flattering light there is.
- ✓ **Blue hour** — the ~20 minutes after sunset. Deep blue sky, glowing lights, glassy water. Bring a tripod.
- ✓ **Stay late.** The best color often comes *after* the sun is gone. Most people leave too early.
- ✓ **Face away from the sun too.** The eastern sky often glows a soft pink while everyone points west.

CARD 04

Video: The One Rule That Fixes the Look

If your video looks like a home movie, it's usually the shutter speed. Match it to your frame rate — the **180° rule**.

Frame rate	Shutter speed	Use it for
24 fps	1/50s	The cinematic, "film" look
30 fps	1/60s	Standard web / social video
60 fps	1/125s	Smooth motion & slow-motion



Bright day?

To keep that slow shutter outdoors you'll need an **ND filter** — think of it as sunglasses for your lens. It's the one accessory that makes video look pro.

CARD 05

Drone: Pre-Flight in 30 Seconds

Most crashes and flyaways are prevented on the ground. Run this before every flight.

- ☒ Firmware & app updated; propellers checked for cracks
- ☒ Batteries charged (drone *and* controller); SD card in with space
- ☒ Enough GPS satellites & home point set
- ☒ **Return-to-Home altitude set above the tallest nearby obstacle**
- ☒ Wind & weather within your drone's limit
- ☒ Airspace checked and legal to fly; clear line of sight



Two habits that save drones

Land at ~30% battery — don't chase one more shot. And in the US, any flight *for money* needs an FAA Part 107 certificate. Always verify current rules before you fly.

YOU'VE GOT THE BASICS — NOW GO DEEPER

This is the tip of the iceberg. The full guides walk you through every one of these, step by step, with the settings and workflows the pros use.

Story Mode Guy

Full photography, video & drone guides at storymodeguy.com/learn · Guides for people who treat everything like it has a plot.